destination regions, permanent settlement was and is simply not possible due to horrendous and astronomically priced housing options, as in congested cities, and strict legislations on citizenship, as is the case with Gulf countries. The inability to settle due to hostile conditions in the destination regions automatically structured circulatory migration strategies. An even more powerful reason occurred in the source regions and revolved around gender norms. If caste norms had the ability to restrict one's movement overseas for certain periods in Indian history, gender norms almost always restricted women's mobility apart from marriage. This was noted by the post office when it was forced to change its money order delivery practices in the late 19th century. It was noted when I would ask the most awkward question on my interview schedule as part of research in 2011: 'Why don't you bring your wife to the city?' The answers or counter-questions of the migrant workers were nearly unanimous: 'Who will look after my parents back home?', 'What will she do here?'[98]

Not surprisingly, many migrants who had moved to the cities with their families had done so because their parents were either dead or did not require support. The second counter-question also points towards the demand for female labour in the destination region. Departures from the general pattern of the Great Indian Migration Wave occurred precisely when women could also work in destination regions such as the tea plantations of Assam and Sri Lanka and garment knitting textile hubs across India.

The regions affected by the Great Indian Migration Wave now have rich migration cultures embodied in songs, festivals and conversations. If you grew up in these regions, you are more likely to migrate during your lifetime and get infected by the adventurous spirit as it appears to be the general norm. These regions are also remittance economies with strong consumerist cultures, little manufacturing and a booming service economy. Women in particular gain considerable autonomy in nuclear families given the absence of their husbands but not so much in other family structures. They also have to look after the agricultural land and are less likely to participate in other sectors.[99] Most importantly, the Great Indian Migration